



Stop Thief! Drop That Coupon

“I couldn’t bother to take the time to use coupons. It’s just pennies,” a friend once commented. At the time, I was regularly saving thirty dollars a week on my grocery bill, an amazing three thousand pennies a week.

Coupons really were worth only a few pennies in the 1950s and 1960s, with average face values of five to twenty cents, hardly “big money” even then. Yet in skimming through newspaper archives, I came across an August 27, 1951, *New York Times* article estimating illegal cashing in of coupons to be a million dollars a year. One of the largest swindles reported was in early 1950 when a company sent out 1,000,000 postcards that offered housewives in the metropolitan area free tea bags, with a redemption value of 21 cents. A letter carrier in Brooklyn stole the cards, sold them to a news dealer for 8 cents each, who in turn sold them to a grocer for 9 cents each. That grocer sold the cards to fellow grocers for 13 cents each. Seems like an awful lot of trouble to make a few pennies. The wholesaler who was reimbursing the grocers to the tune of 21 cents each for boxes of tea bags that hadn’t even been sold lost fifty thousand dollars before the illegal scheme was revealed. Just thirteen years later, eight men were indicted in Brooklyn for illicitly obtaining and selling coupons to the tune of one hundred thousand dollars.